

ANI

SWITCH HIT
Tejashwi Yadav welcomes the four AIMIM MLAs into the RJD

BIHAR

The Turncoat Effect

By Amitabh Srivastava

In the evening of June 29, four legislators who had joined the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) removed their footwear before entering party chief Lalu Prasad's room to seek his blessings. The four MLAs—Muhammed Izhar Asfi, Shahnawaz Alam, Syed Ruknuddin Ahmad and Mohammed Anzar Nayeemi—had won their seats in the 2020 assembly polls for the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM). Their defection has left the Asaduddin Owaisi-led party with one MLA in Bihar—Akhtarul Iman.

When BJP spokesman Nikhil Anand ridiculed the gesture as a sign of servility, many described his comment as an expression of envy. After all, with these inductions taking its strength to 80 MLAs, the RJD has once again become the single largest party in the 243-member legislative assembly. Just three months ago, the BJP had used the same method to become the largest party in the assembly for the first time by inducting all three MLAs of the Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP)—Raju Singh, Swarna Singh and Mishrilal Yadav—but even that left it with only 77 MLAs.

Actually, the AIMIM, with its lone MLA, is better placed than parties like VIP, the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) that have lost their entire legislative presence in the state due to such switchovers. Ironically, the Mukesh Sahani-led VIP was a BJP ally in the 2020 polls. In its push to expand its own footprint, the BJP offered no concession even to allies. In February 2021, it had inducted Nutan Singh, the lone LJP MLC, leaving Chirag Paswan's party without representation in the legislative council. Two months later, Paswan's party also lost its only MLA, Raj Kumar Singh, to the Janata Dal (United).

Visibly upset at the RJD and the turncoats, Iman said, "They have betrayed the people's mandate and will have to pay for it." VIP chief Sahani calls for a constitutional amendment. "Small parties like ours are easy prey for big parties like the BJP, which have made the 10th schedule (the anti-defection law) ineffective. There should be a rule that any MLA or MP who switches sides mid-term would lose his seat...," says Sahani, who now has no MLAs.

The 2020 assembly election had seen the rise of several small parties, with five MLAs from AIMIM, four each from VIP and the Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) or HAM(S) led by former CM Jitan Ram Manjhi, and one each from the LJP and the BSP. They were expected to play a big role as no top party could muster a majority on its own. Having bagged just 74 and 43

BIHAR ASSEMBLY AFTER 2020 POLLS

SMALLER PARTIES WITH 5 OR FEWER MLAS

↘ LJP-1, BSP-1, AIMIM-5, HAM(S)-4, VIP-4, CPI-2, CPI (M)-2

CURRENT STATUS

↘ LJP, BSP and VIP no longer exist in the assembly, having lost all MLAs to bigger parties, while AIMIM is left with just 1 MLA

↘ Beneficiaries: RJD inducted 4 AIMIM MLAs, BJP got 3 VIP MLAs while JD-U has bagged the solitary MLAs from BSP and LJP